tenets. The metaphors used by scholars to describe Hinduism have ranged from the banyan tree and the jungle to a kaleidoscope and even a pan of lasagne. One scholar has pointed out that 'Hinduism' can stand for a civilisation as 'Hellenism' does, and also for a faith as 'Judaism' does; political ideologues in the mid twentieth century insisted it also stood for a 'race' of people embraced by its beliefs. But isn't it also true that our Indian understanding of what 'religion' means has been so drastically affected by colonisation, secularisation, modernity and interaction with global currents, that our own way of conceptualising our native conglomeration of tradition, belief and faith is irretrievably lost?

I cannot be sure, and yet I would argue it does not matter. Some might suggest that this book is an exercise in attempting to fit something unwieldy and unclassifiable into terms an English-speaking twenty-first century reader can understand.[1] Would what we call today 'Hinduism' be recognised by Yajnavalkya (mentioned in the Upanishads, as distinct from the putative author of the *Yajnavalkya-smriti*, mentioned later) or even Adi Shankara who reinterpreted the same faith nearly 2,000 years later? In essence, can today's Hinduism be divorced from the journeys that this aggregate of faiths took over three millennia of enquiry and exploration, resistance to assault and creative reform? Is it even possible, a thoughtful friend asks me, to think of Hinduism as 'pristine' and thus implicitly to say 'I am Hindu' without acknowledging that what one means is not some eternal category of belief but a set of self-descriptors that is contingent on history?

Some may well suggest that my portrayal of Hinduism means that I too have joined those who seek to 'tame' this most unruly of belief systems. Critics allege that the Indian secular liberals want to do just that to Hinduism because they cannot understand religious belief, while the Hindutvavadis want to do so because they cannot control too diverse a set of beliefs. Both sets of attempts result in an effort to 'homogenise' Hinduism for various ends. But the quotidian practices of Hindus involve intense prayer and meditation as well as fierce and bloody rituals, slavish devotion to gurus as well as philosophically abstruse speculations—a range of conduct that has little respect for a writer's need to describe religious phenomena in coherent terms.